

LANGUAGE & CULTURE

# The Myth of British Politeness

Decode what British people say — and what they may really mean.

# Direct or indirect?

If you want someone to move out of your way, what do you say?



## Direct

What would you say directly?



## Polite

What would you say politely?

Compare your answers with a partner.

# What does this really mean?

LISTEN CLOSELY

**“Oooh, could I just squeeze past you?”**

Work in pairs: is this a request, a hint, or something stronger?



# Four words for today

Match each word with its definition. Then check with a partner.

| | |
|---|---|
| **stereotype** | a phrase that sounds polite but means something else |
| **confrontation** | a fixed idea about a group that may not be true |
| **polite-ism** | to force your presence or opinions on someone |
| **to impose** | a situation where people argue or fight because they have different opinions |

# The reading question

Everyone knows that British people are extremely polite. But is this stereotype actually true?

**Skim the text for one minute.**

**Find the main idea:**

real politeness, a cultural code, or something else?



# The British “polite code”

**83%**

of people in the UK say they avoid arguments at all costs.

**14**

polite-isms per day on average.

**not imposing**

The cultural value behind it.

Read closely: what does this make easier — and what can it make confusing?

# Say it — mean it?

| What a British person says | What they really mean |
| --- | --- |
| Oooh, could I just squeeze past you? | **Get out of my way** |
| Sounds fun, I’ll let you know. | **I’m not coming** |

# Check your understanding

1. What percentage of British people try to avoid arguments?

2. How many polite-isms do Britons use per day on average?

3. What cultural value is behind this behaviour?

4. Why might indirect language confuse foreigners?

# Cultural Translator

Work in groups. Rewrite each direct message in two ways:

## British version

indirect and polite

## Our country version

natural in your culture

1. The food your host cooked is terrible.
2. You need a colleague to stop talking so you can work.
3. You do not want to go to your friend’s party.



# Dialogue of Cultures

Work in pairs or small groups. Discuss direct and indirect communication:

## Direct communication

- Clear and fast
- Can sound rude or blunt

## Indirect communication

- Polite and considerate
- Can be unclear or confusing

## Discuss

1. Which style is more common in your country?
2. What misunderstandings can happen between the two styles?
3. Which style would you prefer at work? Why?